knees. He fasted every Saturday, even as a teenager, and his avoidance of all sinful thoughts and activity ‘and his dislike of fine clothes won him from his brothers the nickname of the Stoic’. By the time he was sixteen, he scourged himself every day, wore a hair shirt against his skin to torment the flesh and was fasting almost continually. He told his servants that he dreamed of going to a faraway place like Hindustan and dying for Christ. The choice of Hindustan was not an altogether whimsical one for the young Acquaviva, for that country was the very raison-d’etre for the Order of Jesuits, which he dreamed of joining. The founder of the order, Ignatius of Loyola, had sent Francis Xavier in 1542 to Goa where he took over the running of the College of St Paul by the teal Mandovi River. When Francis Xavier died ten years later in 1552, there were sixty-four Jesuits working in Hindustan and the object of all Acquaviva’s lonely scourgings was to join their number.

It was at this time, late in the winter of 1564, that Bega Begum left to perform the hajj. Akbar was reluctant to see his stepmother go so this was clearly a religious obligation Bega Begum was keen to perform for herself. Having started the building works at Humayun’s tomb by this time, Bega Begum sailed away to Mecca and disappeared from Mughal records for the next three years. Akbar also turned his attention to the temples of Mathura once again. On a report submitted by Raja Bharmal in 1565, Akbar gave 200 bighas of land in inam (revenue-free gift) to Gopaldas, priest at the Govind Dev and Madan Mohan temples, both of the Chaitanya sects.

In the spring of 1565, Akbar set off once again for Narwar, purportedly to hunt elephants but also to finally requisition the treasure from Gondwana that Asaf Khan had misappropriated and to check on the loyalty of this famously flighty officer. It was around this time that, without much fanfare, Akbar ordered the execution of Kamran’s son, his cousin Abu’l Qasim Khan, a prisoner in Gwalior these many years. According to the contemporary writer Muhammad Arif Qandahari, the man appointed to carry out this execution was the son of Raja Bharmal, showing the extraordinarily high confidence Akbar now had in his Kachhwaha relatives. With his empire simmering with rebellion, a hostile prince of royal blood would have been considered potentially too dangerous, and could no longer be allowed to languish at Gwalior. The cause of Akbar’s many alliances and actions at this time was mainly to neutralize the danger posed by the old Timurid system of co-sovereignty in which all princes had an equal right to